MODULE 17 · DOMAIN 2 - PROCESS

Business case, charter and the integrated plan

Why a project exists, how it is authorised, and how one integrated plan holds every part together, in any approach.

DOMAIN II - Process EXAM WEIGHT 41% MODULE 17 of 49

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The business case says **why**. The charter says **go**. The plan says **how**.

From need to plan

01

Needs assessment

What problem or opportunity exists?

02

Business case

Options, costs, benefits, a recommendation.

03

Benefits plan

Which benefits, when, measured how, owned by whom.

04

Project charter

Authorises the project and the PM.

05

Integrated plan

How the work will be delivered and controlled.

ON THE EXAM

The first three usually exist before the project does. The project manager uses them, and keeps checking them.

The business case

- The **problem or opportunity**, and why it matters now.
- **Options** analysed, including doing nothing, with costs, benefits and risks.
- The **recommended option** and its success criteria.
- Owned by the **sponsor**. Revisited at gates and whenever the environment changes.
- A business case that no longer holds is a signal to raise, not a document to ignore.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The outline asks you to assess plans for continued business value. The business case is the yardstick.

The benefits management plan

- **Target benefits** and how each will be measured.
- **When** each benefit is expected, often after the project has closed.
- A **benefit owner**, usually in the business, not the project team.
- The **assumptions and risks** that could stop benefits arriving.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Benefits often arrive after closure. Someone in the business must own and measure them.

What the project charter contains

SECTION	EXAMPLES
Purpose and objectives	Why the project exists; measurable objectives and success criteria
High-level scope and requirements	What is in, what is out, at a summary level
Summary milestones and budget	Key dates; pre-approved financial resources
High-level risks, assumptions, constraints	The main known uncertainties and limits
Key stakeholders	Who is affected and involved
Authority	The named project manager, their authority level, and the sponsor
Approval requirements	What defines success and who signs off

ON THE EXAM

The charter is deliberately high-level. Detail belongs in the plan.

What the charter does

- **Formally authorises** the project to exist and to use organisational resources.
- Gives the **project manager authority** to apply those resources.
- Issued by the **sponsor** or another initiator outside the project. The PM may help draft it.
- Without a charter, the project manager has no formal authority, and the project has no agreed purpose.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> No charter, no project. Asked to start planning without one? Work with the sponsor to get it first.

Assumptions and constraints

- **Assumptions**: things believed true for planning, without proof. 'The supplier's API will be ready in month three.'
- **Constraints**: limits the project must work within. 'Go-live before the financial year end.'
- Record both in an **assumption log**, and validate assumptions as the project proceeds.
- An assumption proven false is a risk or an issue. Update the log and assess the impact.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Every assumption is a risk in disguise. Log it, check it, and act when it turns out to be wrong.

Assessing needs, complexity and magnitude

- **Size**: budget, duration, number of people, teams and sites.
- **Uncertainty**: how clear are requirements, technology and the environment?
- **Complexity**: interdependencies, stakeholders, regulation, organisational change.
- The assessment drives the **approach**, the **governance** level, and how much **planning** is enough.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A small, clear project needs a light plan. A large, complex one needs more structure. Tailor to the assessment.

Critical information, including sustainability

- The outline asks you to **determine critical information requirements**, naming **sustainability** as an example.
- Environmental: carbon, energy, materials, waste, and what happens at end of life.
- Social and economic: effects on communities, workers, suppliers and long-term costs.
- Capture sustainability requirements early, with stakeholders, and build them into objectives and success criteria.

ON THE EXAM

Sustainability is planned in, not added later. It is a PMBOK 8 principle and an outline enabler.

The integrated project management plan

PART	CONTENTS
Subsidiary plans	Scope, schedule, finance, quality, resources, communications, risk, procurement, stakeholder engagement
Baselines	Scope, schedule and cost; together, the performance measurement baseline
Other components	Change management and configuration management plans, life cycle, development approach
Adaptive equivalents	Product vision, roadmap, release and iteration plans, product backlog

ON THE EXAM

One integrated plan, however many parts. A change to one part is checked for its effect on all the others.

Integration: gaps and dependencies

- The outline asks you to **assess plans for dependencies, gaps and continued business value**.
- Check the parts agree: does the schedule assume people the resource plan never provides?
- Check dependencies between workstreams, teams, suppliers and other projects.
- Subsidiary plans written separately, never reconciled, are a classic source of failure.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The project manager's integrating role: make the parts consistent, and keep them consistent as they change.

Progressive elaboration and rolling wave planning

- **Progressive elaboration**: the plan gains detail as more becomes known.
- **Rolling wave planning**: near-term work in detail, later work at a higher level.
- Detail the next phase or release as it approaches, and keep later phases as milestones and estimates.
- Detailed plans for work two years away are mostly guesses that will need rework.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Plan in detail what you can see clearly. Keep the rest at the level of confidence you actually have.

Predictive or adaptive planning?

PREDICTIVE

Plan the whole, then control

- Detailed plan and baselines early
- Scope fixed; time and cost estimated
- Change through formal control
- Progress against the baseline

ADAPTIVE

Plan in layers, often

- Vision, roadmap, release, iteration
- Time and cost often fixed; scope flexes
- Change through the backlog
- Progress in working increments

THE TIEBREAKER

Both plan. Predictive plans more up front; adaptive plans more often. Hybrid does both, per workstream.

Recommending an execution strategy

- **Build or buy**: in-house, outsourced, or a mix.
- **Phasing**: one delivery, phased roll-out, pilot first, or continuous releases.
- **Sequencing**: what must come first for risk, value or dependency reasons.
- A **pilot** reduces risk when the change is large and the organisation untested.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The execution strategy turns the chosen approach into a practical route. Recommend it with reasons.

Data-driven planning decisions

- The outline asks you to **collect and analyse data to make informed project decisions**.
- Use **historical data and benchmarks** from similar projects for estimates.
- Use the team's own measured performance, such as velocity or throughput, once available.
- Plans built on optimism rather than evidence are the most common cause of late projects.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Base plans on evidence. When evidence is thin, say so, and plan to gather more.

Approval, baselines and change

- The plan is **approved** by the appropriate authority, and baselines are set.
- After that, baselines change only through **change control**.
- The plan itself is **maintained**: updated as the project learns, with changes recorded.
- Quietly editing a baseline to hide a variance is not maintenance. It is misreporting.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Baselines are for measuring against. They move only through the agreed change process.

Project Lantern: from case to plan

- **Business case**: missed appointments cost Northgate heavily; options included doing nothing and buying a hosted service.
- **Benefit**: missed appointments down by a quarter within a year of the last go-live, owned by the head of patient access.
- **Charter**: signed by the chief operating officer; names the PM with authority over contingency up to an agreed limit.
- **Plan**: hybrid; baselines for hardware and migration, roadmap and backlog for the app, a pilot clinic first.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Why, go, how: three documents, each doing its own job, all consistent with each other.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
Asked to plan, no charter exists	Work with the sponsor to get a charter first
The business case no longer holds	Raise it with the sponsor, with analysis
Two plans contradict each other	Reconcile them; update the integrated plan
Organisation has sustainability commitments	Capture them as requirements and success criteria
Long project, later phases unclear	Rolling wave: detail near-term, elaborate later
A planning assumption proves false	Update the log, assess impact, treat as risk or issue

ON THE EXAM

Why, go, how. Keep all three current and consistent, and the plan evidence-based.

> A department head tells a project manager in a corridor conversation to 'get started on the new supplier portal' and to have a plan ready in two weeks.
>
> No charter or business case has been shared, and nobody has confirmed the budget or the project manager's authority.

What should the project manager do first?

A Start creating the work breakdown structure to save time.

B Work with the department head, as sponsor, to develop and approve a project charter.

C Hold a kickoff meeting with the likely team members.

D Begin contacting possible suppliers for quotes.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do first?

A Start the WBS.

Plans work with no agreed purpose, scope or authority.

B Develop and approve a charter with the sponsor.

Authorises the project and the PM, and agrees purpose and objectives first.

C Kickoff meeting.

Commits people's time to a project that does not formally exist yet.

D Contact suppliers.

Commercial activity without authority or budget is a real risk.

THE SIGNAL

No charter, no authority. Get the project formally authorised before planning or committing anything.

> A project is building an app to help customers claim a government energy rebate. Halfway through, the government announces the rebate will end in three months.
>
> The business case assumed two years of claims. The project is on schedule and on budget.

What should the project manager do?

A Continue as planned, since the project is on schedule and on budget.

B Cut scope to finish sooner and reduce cost.

C Analyse the impact on the business case and bring it to the sponsor to decide the project's future.

D Ask the team to work faster so the app launches before the rebate ends.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A. Continue as planned.
On time and on budget towards value that no longer exists.

B. Cut scope to finish sooner.
A unilateral response that assumes the project should continue at all.

C. Analyse; take it to the sponsor.
Assesses continued business value, and puts the decision with its owner.

D. Work faster.
Assumes a three-month window is worth the cost and strain. Nobody has checked.

THE SIGNAL

When the business case collapses, the sponsor decides the project's future, with your analysis.

> While reviewing the plan, the project manager notices that the schedule assumes six testers during the final month, but the resource management plan allocates only three.
>
> Both plans were approved by their respective owners.

What should the project manager do?

A. Follow the schedule, and request three more testers when the final month arrives.

B. Reconcile the two plans with their owners, and update the integrated plan.

C. Follow the resource plan, since resources are the harder constraint.

D. Escalate the contradiction to the steering committee.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Request testers later.

Leaves the gap until it is too late to fix cheaply.

B Reconcile with the owners; update the plan.

Integration: find the gap now, resolve it, keep the plan consistent.

C Follow the resource plan.

Silently accepts a schedule that cannot be met.

D Escalate.

A planning gap the PM can resolve with the plan owners.

THE SIGNAL

Two plans that contradict each other: that is exactly the gap the outline asks you to find and fix.

> A project manager is planning an office refurbishment for a company that has publicly committed to reaching net zero emissions.
>
> The contract with the fit-out firm says nothing about sustainability, and the budget is tight.

What should the project manager do?

A Leave sustainability out, since it is not in the contract.

B Plan the refurbishment now and add sustainability measures if budget remains.

C Identify the sustainability requirements with stakeholders, and build them into objectives and success criteria.

D Leave sustainability decisions to the fit-out firm.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Leave it out.

Ignores a stated organisational commitment. The contract can be updated.

B Add it if money is left.

Treats sustainability as optional extra, which the principles reject.

C Identify requirements; build them into objectives.

Critical information captured early, where it can shape design and cost.

D Leave it to the contractor.

Hands an organisational commitment to a party with no obligation to meet it.

THE SIGNAL

An organisational sustainability commitment is critical information. Plan it in, from the start.

> A three-year programme will replace a bank's core systems in three phases. Phase one is well understood. Phases two and three depend on vendor decisions not yet made.
>
> The sponsor asks for a fully detailed schedule for all three phases at the start.

How should the project manager respond?

A Plan phase one in detail, keep later phases at milestone level, and elaborate each as it approaches.

B Build a fully detailed schedule for all three phases, using assumptions for the unknowns.

C Plan phase one only, and leave later phases unplanned.

D Delay the start until the vendor decisions are made.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the project manager respond?

A Rolling wave planning.

Detail where knowledge exists, milestones where it does not, elaborated over time.

B Full detail on assumptions.

False precision. Most of it will be reworked once vendors are chosen.

C No plan for later phases.

Leaves the sponsor with no view of the overall programme.

D Delay the start.

Wastes time on phase one, which is ready to go.

THE SIGNAL

Detail what you know; outline what you do not. Explain to the sponsor why that is more reliable.

> The assumption log records that a partner's data interface would be available in month three. The partner now says it will not be ready until month six.
>
> Several work packages depend on the interface.

What should the project manager do next?

A Continue as planned, since the partner may still deliver earlier.

B Record the delay as the partner's fault in the project documents.

C Rebaseline the schedule to month six straight away.

D Update the assumption log, assess the impact on dependent work, and respond through the risk and change processes.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do next?

A Carry on.

Ignores new, specific information that a planning assumption is false.

B Record the partner's fault.

Blame does nothing for the dependent work.

C Rebaseline immediately.

Skips impact analysis and the change process; there may be workarounds.

D Update log, assess impact, use risk and change processes.

A false assumption becomes a risk or issue, handled through the proper processes.

THE SIGNAL

A failed assumption is a risk or issue now. Log it, assess it, and act through the proper processes.

Why, go, how. Keep them consistent, and keep checking the why.